

# Subject-Verb Agreement

Subject-verb agreement simply means that the subject and verb in a sentence must agree in number. They both need to be singular, or they both need to be plural.

## Subject-verb agreement in singular subjects and verbs

1. My **dog** waits for the postal carrier.
2. **I** understand the assignment.
3. **Peter** likes vegetables.

## Subject-verb agreement in plural subjects and verbs

1. **Basketballs** roll across the floor.
2. **These clothes** are too small for me.
3. **The cats** meow at the door.

## Compound Subjects

Compound subjects are two subjects in the same sentence. They usually take a plural verb, unless the combination is treated as singular in popular usage or the two subjects refer to the same thing or person.

1. **Sugar and flour** are needed for the recipe.
2. **Neither my dad nor my brothers** know how to ski.
3. **Pepperoni and cheese** are great on a pizza.
4. **Corned beef and cabbage** is a traditional meal in Ireland. (popular usage)
5. **The creator and producer** is arriving soon. (both refer to the same person)

When using “or” or “nor” in a compound subject containing a singular and plural subject, the verb agrees with the closest subject.

1. **My mom or dad** is coming to the play. (both nouns are singular)
2. **Neither gray nor white** is my favorite color. (both nouns are singular)
3. **Either Grandpa or my sisters** are going to the park. (the closest subject is plural)
4. **Either my sisters or Grandpa** is going to the park. (the closest subject is singular)
5. **Neither she nor I** am going to college. (the closest subject is singular)

## Singular Indefinite Pronouns

Indefinite pronouns stand in for nouns that are unknown, unclear or uncountable. They can be singular or plural, depending on what nouns they are replacing.

1. **Each** gets a trophy for playing.
2. **Somebody** will pay for this.

3. **Anybody** is more fun than you.
4. **Something** feels very wrong here.
5. **Everybody** enjoys a good book.
6. **Nothing** has been determined as of yet.

## Plural Indefinite Pronouns

When indefinite pronouns replace plural nouns, they require plural verbs.

1. **Both** are qualified for the job.
2. **Many** went to the beach and got sunburned.
3. **Few** know what it really takes to get ahead.
4. **Several** are already on location.
5. **Some sugar** is required for taste. (sugar is uncountable so singular verb used)
6. **Most of the cookies** were eaten. (cookies are countable so plural verb used)

## Noun Phrase as Subject

1. **A theory of physics** ascertains that a body in motion stays in motion.
2. **A virus in all the company's computers** is a real threat to security.
3. **The causes of this prevalent disease** are bad diet and lack of exercise.
4. **The couch and chair** I got at the store look really nice in here.
5. **The members of the choir** are very happy with the performance.

## Collective Nouns

Collective nouns, which are words that represent groups of nouns, are typically singular in American English.

1. **The committee** meets here every Thursday.
2. **The crowd** is getting angry.
3. **The jury** has finally reached a decision.
4. **The majority** rules most of the time.
5. **The staff** has gone their separate ways for the holidays.

## Inverted Subjects

When subjects appear after verbs in the sentence, they're known as inverted subjects.

1. There are seven clean **plates** in the dining room.
2. There is **a hair** in my lasagna.
3. Over the rainbow flies **a bird**.
4. How are **the employees** enjoying the new building?
5. A good gift is **a gift card**.